

World in Brief: Todd Blanche confirmed as attorney-general; Spain imposes border restrictions on Italy



Photograph: Getty Images

America's Senate confirmed **Todd Blanche**—Donald Trump's former personal lawyer—as attorney-general. Mr Blanche sparked outrage for agreeing to create a [\\$1.8bn fund](#) to compensate political allies of Mr Trump over alleged government “lawfare”. Sceptical Republicans were won over only when he formally scrapped it. Two Republicans—Susan Collins of Maine and Lisa Murkowski of Alaska—still voted against him.

The Senate also passed a bill to fund federal agencies until December 11th. America will now be spared the prospect of a **government shutdown** in September, five weeks before the midterm elections. Democrats got behind the bill after they secured a provision barring the transfer of federal funds to the Border Patrol agency. A government shutdown last October [lasted](#) 43 days, the longest in America's history.

Spain said it would impose border controls on visitors from **Italy**. The temporary measure comes in retaliation to Italy imposing its own restrictions on those entering from Spain following an influx of 72,000 migrants to Cueta, a north African Spanish exclave. (Most of the people subsequently [returned to Morocco](#).) The two EU

countries, which do not share a land border, normally allow visa-free travel between them.

Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, arrived in Belgrade for his first official visit to **Serbia**. The Balkan country has distanced itself from the Kremlin since Russia's [invasion](#) of Ukraine in 2022. Although it refuses to sign up for sanctions against Russia, on which it depends for natural gas, it has scaled down trade with the country and its armed forces have replaced Soviet-era equipment with Western gear.

Typhoon Dolphin battered **Japan's** Okinawa region, injuring six people and causing power outages before heading toward eastern **China**, where ports and ferry routes have been closed. The storm's approach triggered diplomatic tensions after China imposed traffic control measures on ships in the Taiwan Strait, a crucial [shipping route](#) over which China claims sovereignty—a stance rejected by Taiwan and its allies. Taiwan dismissed the restrictions as “ridiculous”.

OpenAI said it was pausing some internal activities around a yet-to-be-released AI model, Astra, citing its “critical [cyber capabilities](#)”. A model reaches the firm's “Critical” threshold when it can identify and develop severe bugs (“zero-day exploits”) without human intervention, or devise novel strategies for high-level cyber-attacks. OpenAI said Astra was not involved in the recent [hacking of Hugging Face](#), an AI platform.

Thailand's prime minister promised to introduce stricter gun laws in the wake of a school shooting that left at least eight people dead, including the student gunman. The 14-year-old attacker killed his two grandparents before heading to the prestigious Debsirin Nonthaburi School, near Bangkok. Anutin Charnvirakul said he would bar everyone except government officials from carrying firearms in public.

Word of the week: *haigui*, or sea turtles in Chinese, describing those who come back to China after their studies abroad. Last year the proportion of returnees was 94% of outbound students, [an all-time high](#).

Have you been following the headlines? Test your knowledge of the news with [our weekly quiz](#).

Can Iran keep weaponising Hormuz?

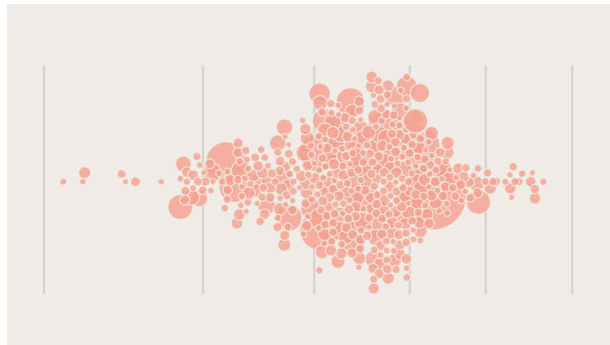


Photograph: Getty Images

Iran and Oman claim to be nearing an arrangement that would allow more traffic through the Strait of Hormuz. The details are sparse. It is not clear whether ships would have to pay to pass—a demand Iran has repeatedly made—or what ships would be allowed. Iran’s parliament is reviewing a bill that would block American and Israeli vessels from crossing the strait. The regime has warned “certain third parties” not to meddle in its plan.

[According to our “Hormuz dependency dashboard”](#), Iran could indeed monetise the strait. It would be exceedingly difficult to reroute shipments of refined petroleum products or liquefied natural gas. And many of Iran’s Gulf neighbours depend on the waterway for imports such as food. But Iran’s ability to cash in would probably diminish over time. Crude can be piped around the strait, and producers elsewhere—not least in the Americas—could expand output. Iran’s pricing power might therefore fade. But its leverage over one of the world’s most vital waterways is unlikely ever to disappear.

Data bite: Why most IPOs are not worth the hype



In June SpaceX made history with a stock market debut that raised \$86bn and valued Elon Musk's rocket-maker above \$2trn. The company reported better-than-expected earnings this week, but its losses and spending unnerved investors, sending its share price down. OpenAI and Anthropic may follow in going public. [The Economist's analysis](#) suggests investors shouldn't let themselves be lured by mega-IPOs.

Tracking more than 3,500 American flotations since 2010 showed that returns varied wildly; snapping up shares is closer to a lottery than an investment. New listings "pop" in their first day or so of trading, but then quickly fizzle out. Data compiled by Jay Ritter of the University of Florida found that firms floated between 1980 and 2024 ended up, on average, lagging the market by 21 percentage points over three years. That said, some companies buck the trend: tech firms with annual sales above \$100m beat the market by 13.7 points.

A fishing competition reels in viewers



Photograph: majorleaguefishing.com

Some sports were made for television. Football, basketball and tennis are all as simple to film as they are to watch live. Others, such as cricket and golf, require more advanced camerawork to capture smaller details for viewers. Then there is Major League Fishing. The bass-fishing competition was dreamed up for television in 2011 with Outdoor Channel, an American network. The final stage of the 2026 season takes place on Saturday on Lake Erie in Ohio, with the Angler of the Year title still up for grabs.

The competition's structure is similar to Formula 1, if slower and with more flip-flops. Top anglers compete at a series of events, accruing points as they go. Once fish are caught they are weighed and released. A live scoreboard tallies their cumulative weight. The winner is the best performer over the season. It is a surprisingly dynamic spectacle, with records that include catching some 165lb of fish in a single day. Fans are hooked.

Weekend profile: Mohammed VI, Morocco's distracted king



Photograph: Getty Images

Nothing was allowed to interrupt Throne Day on July 30th, an annual ritual in which Morocco's elite swear allegiance to the king. Not even the deaths of more than 140 migrants who were crushed as 72,000 people surged towards [the Spanish exclave of Ceuta](#). The security chiefs who should have dispatched reinforcements were just 16 miles away, attending the ceremonies at the royal palace in M'diq. Too busy bowing and hand-kissing to answer their phones, they left border posts all but abandoned. Officers who had spent months keeping would-be migrants at bay had been redeployed to guard the festivities. Only after the ceremony ended, five hours later, were they sent back. As images of desperate Moroccans flashed around the world, state television remained transfixed by the pageantry of the elite. For the *makhzen*, as Morocco's ruling establishment is known, protocol trumps all.

Mohammed VI once promised to be a different kind of ruler. When he succeeded his father, Hassan II, in 1999, he seemed like a breath of fresh air. He toured undeveloped and sometimes unruly areas his father had shunned, earning the moniker "the king of the poor". He dismissed his father's ruthless enforcers, released political prisoners and modernised the country with motorways and high-speed rail. He married—then, to high society's astonishment, divorced—a commoner; swapped suits for T-shirts; went jet-skiing;

and spent long holidays in Paris and Gabon with kickboxers, nightclub owners and comedians.

Over time, however, the *makhzen* reasserted itself. As Mohammed VI's health declined, the state-run media exposed the king's kickboxer friends as gangsters and [drove them from public view](#). Increasingly the *makhzen* looked to his more disciplined and sterner son, Crown Prince Hassan, for leadership; in May he was appointed co-ordinator of the armed forces. The palace appointed an Islamist prime minister to mollify the Arab Spring protests in 2011, but replaced him in 2017 and later backed the elevation of favoured oligarchs to the post. Critics were locked up on trumped-up sex-crime charges. Too frail to resist, the king has acquiesced. When Gen Z-led protests erupted last year, the response was water cannon and jail-terms for some 1,400 young Moroccans. Like his father before him, Mohammed VI has come to embody a monarchy in which ceremony takes precedence. In the wake of Ceuta, he announced that he had named a \$1bn highway in the disputed territory of the Western Sahara, on the opposite end of the country, after Donald Trump (who blamed the tragedy on Spain's socialist government). When disasters strike, the monarch is otherwise engaged.

Mini crossword

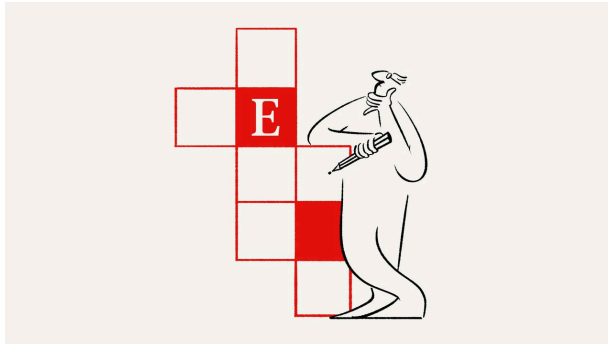


Illustration: The Economist

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Animal eats Ron's first cut of chicken (6)

2 across - Assassin hiding in bamboo thicket (5)

3 across - Cowardly shout. That hurts! (6)

1 down - Fuzzy busy bee is trapped inside fruit (9)

Straight clues

1 across - Robin's is orange actually, not red (6)

2 across - Compartment; small office (5)

3 across - Coldplay's first global hit (6)

1 down - Superfood (9)

The winners of this week's quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Seunghan Lee, Busan, South Korea

Lachlan Philpott, Sydney, Australia

Hattie Ajderian, Exmouth, Britain

They all gave the correct answers of: murder, parliament, Quantum Leap, pod and pride. The theme is collective nouns for animals: a murder of crows, a parliament of owls, a leap of leopards, a pod of dolphins (or whales) and a pride of lions.

The questions were:

Monday: What happens on the Orient Express in the title of the Agatha Christie novel?

Tuesday: The Althing in Iceland is the oldest form of what type of institution?

Wednesday: Which TV series featured Scott Bakula playing the time-travelling scientist, Sam Beckett?

Thursday: What suffix is used in taxonomy to refer to feet?

Friday: Which deadly sin is said to come before a fall?

*Better to die on your feet than live
on your knees!*

Emiliano Zapata